

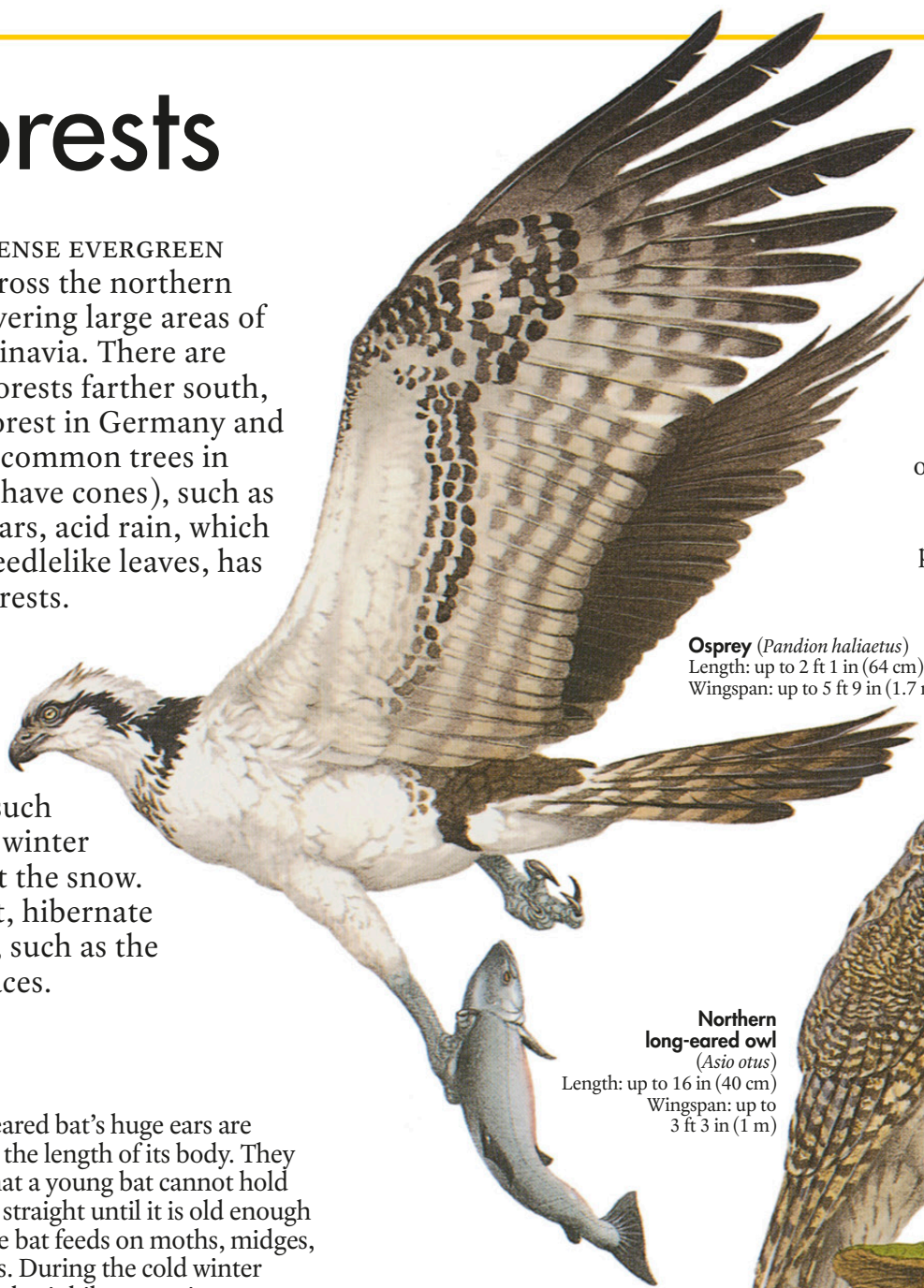
Conifer Forests



A THICK BAND OF DENSE EVERGREEN FOREST stretches across the northern parts of Europe, covering large areas of Scotland and Scandinavia. There are smaller evergreen forests farther south, such as the Black Forest in Germany and the Ardennes in Belgium. The most common trees in these forests are conifers (trees that have cones), such as pines, spruces, and firs. In recent years, acid rain, which is especially harmful to trees with needlelike leaves, has damaged many European conifer forests.

Animals that live in these forests have to survive in a severe climate. The winters are bitterly cold, but most conifer trees keep their leaves year round and provide some shelter. Some forest animals, such as the stoat, grow white coats in the winter so that they are camouflaged against the snow. Other animals, such as the wood ant, hibernate during the winter, while some birds, such as the osprey, migrate south to warmer places.

Fish snatcher
The osprey feeds on fish that it snatches from lakes. It has long, sharp claws and horny spines under its toes, which enable it to grip a slippery fish. An adult osprey can carry a fish weighing up to 4.5 lbs (2 kg). In the fall, the osprey migrates to Africa, where the weather is warmer and there are plenty of fish for it to eat.



Osprey (*Pandion haliaetus*)
Length: up to 2 ft 1 in (64 cm)
Wingspan: up to 5 ft 9 in (1.7 m)

Northern long-eared owl (*Asio otus*)
Length: up to 16 in (40 cm)
Wingspan: up to 3 ft 3 in (1 m)



Long ears

The brown long-eared bat's huge ears are three-quarters the length of its body. They are so big that a young bat cannot hold its ears up straight until it is old enough to fly. The bat feeds on moths, midges, and flies. During the cold winter months, it hibernates in a cave.



Brown long-eared bat (*Plecotus auritus*)
Wingspan: up to 11 in (28 cm)

Underground city

Wood ants build huge nests on the forest floor from pine needles and other plant material. Nests keep the ants warm in winter, when they hibernate in the soil beneath the mound. When threatened, a wood ant sprays its enemy with a stinging liquid called formic acid from glands on its abdomen.



Wood ant (*Formica rufa*) Length: up to 0.35 in (0.9 cm)

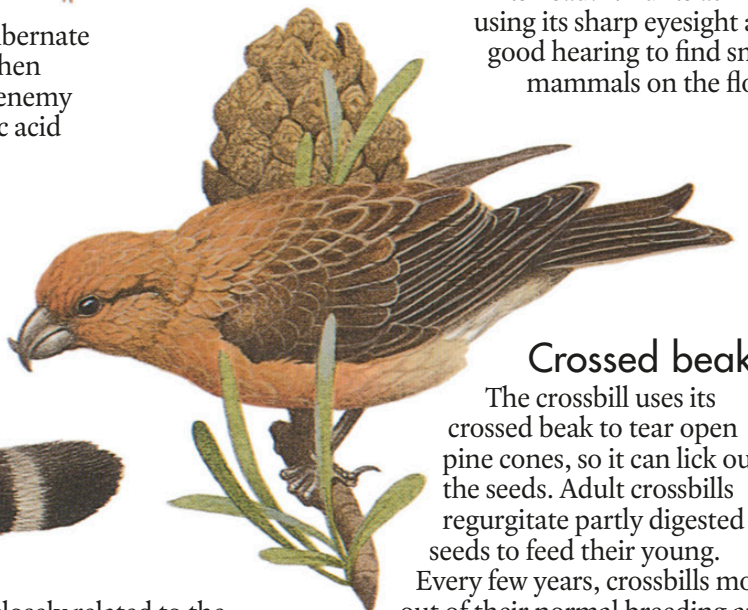
False ears

The "ears" of the northern long-eared owl are only tufts of feathers—its ear openings are on the sides of its head. It hunts at night using its sharp eyesight and good hearing to find small mammals on the floor.

Wild cat (*Felis silvestris*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 5 in (74 cm)
Tail: up to 14.5 in (37 cm)



Red crossbill (*Loxia curvirostra*)
Length: up to 7.8 in (20 cm)



Crossed beak

The crossbill uses its crossed beak to tear open pine cones, so it can lick out the seeds. Adult crossbills regurgitate partly digested seeds to feed their young. Every few years, crossbills move out of their normal breeding areas and invade other parts of Europe. If conditions are good, they may settle in the new area for one or more seasons.

Stripey tail

The wild cat is closely related to the domestic cat, but it is slightly bigger and has a thicker tail with black rings on it. The wild cat hunts at night for small mammals, birds, and insects. The forests provide it with cover for hunting.